



Parasha Nitzavim – Returning to the Ways of God

(Deuteronomy 29:9 – 30:20)

By Michael Nunes (JEWMAICA, Jamaica)

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As evening draws close and the period of rest, relaxation and rejuvenating arrives - the Shabbat, this Shabbat is extra special. It's the Shabbat before the day of *Zicharon Teruah* (See Vayikra/Leviticus 23:24). *Zicharon Teruah* known also, as Rosh HaShanna, New Years (See *Mishna Rosh HaShanna 1.1*), is a seasonal period of renewal. It is at this juncture that we will read this week's Parasha of Nitzavim (Heb. for upright standing).

Today, Nitzavim speaks to this generation, you who are the descendants of Yisrael who had stood listening to Moses. Netzavim is speaking to the galuth (the exiled Yisralite), who might have become lost, landless, oppressed, and/or even without the identity or the memory there of, due to the galuth (exile) – Netzavim says, stand up, trust the covenant, trust God – the covenant is also is for all of us.

O' Zion awake

"I make this covenant, with its sanctions, not with you alone, but both with those who are standing here with us this day before our God יְהוָה and with those who are not with us here this day."

[Deuteronomy 29:13-14]

O' Zion Hear

At a juncture when Yisrael had spread across the lands of the Hellenes, the leaders then had sought to provide them with the Torah in their new foreign spoken tongue. This was done with the hope that Yisrael might always cleave only to it. However, even at this juncture, there were those who had always detested the people and with zeal and quest to now usurped, later found in an action that was meant for good, opportunities for not only usurping but subjugation. Yet, knowing the people's stubbornness it too was foretold. However, so too Yisrael's redemption:

"Your God יְהוָה will inflict all those curses upon the enemies and foes who persecuted you."

[Deuteronomy 30:7]

O' Zion Return!

For *"You, however, will again heed יְהוָה and obey all the divine commandments that I enjoin upon you this day."*

[Deuteronomy 30:8]

“Then your God יהוה will open up your heart and the hearts of your offspring—to love your God יהוה with all your heart and soul, in order that you may live.”

[Deuteronomy 30:6]

O’ Zion Arise!

“When all these things befall you—the blessing and the curse that I have set before you—and you take them to heart amidst the various nations to which your God יהוה has banished you, and you return to your God יהוה, and you and your children heed God’s command with all your heart and soul, just as I enjoin upon you this day,”

[Deuteronomy 30:1-2]

O’ Zion Awake, O’ Zion Hear, O’ Zion Return!

Moses was known to say (See Numbers 10:35-36):

יָגִסוּ מִשְׁנֵאֵיךָ מִפְּנֵי־קוֹמָהּ יְהוָה וַיִּפְצוּ אֹיְבֶיךָ וְ
שׁוֹבָה יְהוָה רַבְבוֹת אֱלֹפֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל

*“Rise up, יהוה, and let thy enemies be scattered; and let those who hate thee flee before thee!
Return, יהוה, to the ten thousand thousands of Yisra’el.*

בְּנִיךָ חוֹן תַּחֲוֹן עַל – Be gracious, be gracious upon Your children.
לְךָ שׁוֹבִים – To You (they are) returning.

Shabbat Shalom and a Happy New Year when it comes